What is this thing?

Lesson 1: what a language model is, and why it can sound sure and still be wrong.

Check the Source · 45 minutes

Finish the sentence

- Once upon a …
- Peanut butter and …
- The capital of Wisconsin is …
- The author of *[a book in our library]* is …

You just did what it does

You picked the word that usually comes next. When you'd seen the pattern a lot, you were right. When you hadn't, you still answered. Some of you sounded sure.

That's a language model.

What a language model is

A language model read an enormous amount of text and learned which words tend to **follow** which.

When you ask it something, it writes an answer one piece at a time, each time picking a **likely** next piece.

Two things it is not

Not a search engine

It does not **look things up** unless something hands it sources. On its own, it remembers patterns.

Not a person who knows

It does not know when it is wrong. It sounds the same when it's right and when it's **guessing**.

A confident wrong answer is called a **hallucination**.

If it sounds sure either way, how could you tell?

You check it against something **real**.

Every answer has two parts

1. The overview

The model's **own words**, from what it already knows. It can be wrong and has no Citations.

2. Books in our library

Real books from our Catalog. Each has a **Citation**: title and call number.

This can be wrong, check the source.

Your Card

- It lets your group use the assistant **for this period**.
- It has a number on it. The assistant **never learns your name**.
- The librarian can see the questions, with the Card number.
- Ask about books and topics. **Don't type** your full name, address, or phone number, or anyone else's.

Your turn: first questions

Roles

Typer, reader, checker, recorder. Swap after each question.

Ask two

"What do we have about …?"

"I liked [title]. What should I read next?"

Record

Fill in the table on the back of your handout.

Before you go

Answer on your exit ticket:

1. True or false, and why: "If the assistant sounds really sure, the answer is right."
2. Finish the sentence: "A language model writes by …"
3. The banner says to check the source. What is *the source*?